

Introduction

Charles Malik

I

We are thrown into this world of struggle and care. We made neither our world nor ourselves: we *find* ourselves in this state. Before we can even ask the question "Why?" we must first exist, and, existing, we must recognize our condition such as it is: we are beings of care, beings who have our mind on all sorts of problems and concerns. Only such an existing being can "recognize" his state, and, in recognizing it, can ask the question "Why?" about it or about any other thing. The man who is not struggling or the man who is completely carefree does not exist. This is our human condition, this is what it means *to be* a man, this is our fate. Here the word "fate" has nothing to do with chance or fatalism, with predestination or the necessity of nature, if by any of these terms is meant that in struggling and caring we are not essentially free and accountable. Any notion that for anything involving our caring decision we can invoke some *kismet*, some *deus ex machine*, to relieve us of responsibility for that decision is utterly foreign to our mind. Man is as *fated* and *doomed* to be free and responsible as to struggle and care. He is thrown into this world and left to struggle and swim on his own. In fact, it is precisely because his possibilities are never completely closed before him, but he can always throw himself upon any one of them (at least he can be silly or he can be true), that his life is ever a life of struggling care. He cares and struggles *because* he is free; because, that is, he can always be one of a number of possibilities, and in being one, he has thereby for that occasion categorically excluded all the rest. This natural tragedy (the hallmark of his human limitation) whereby there is ruthless *destruction* of possibilities on every decision and choice is the ultimate ground of his anguish. His heart aches because he *must* destroy. But *what* he must destroy, *that* is left to his freedom. When we say, "This is our fate," we mean this is our essential nature, this is the sort of being we are. And this being originally and inalienably includes our freedom.

All this is part, indeed it is but the elementary part, of the teaching of Heidegger.⁴ But regardless of Heidegger's ultimate motives in not wanting explicitly to ground this fundamental insight in the Judaeo-Christian tradition (it is quite reasonable to suppose that, personally-existentially, he himself owes it to this tradition), but choosing instead to invoke a fable from outside this tradition, a fable "which is pre-ontological in character" and whose "demonstrative force is 'merely historical,'" ⁵ this insight is absolutely integral to the Judaeo-Christian tradition. The Old Testament begins with this judgment upon man, which appears essentially to have stamped his being for all time:

And the Lord God called unto Adam, and said unto him, Where art thou? And he said, I heard thy voice in the garden, and I was afraid, because I was naked; and I hid myself....And unto Adam [the Lord God] said, Because thou hast.... eaten of the tree....cursed is the ground for thy sake; in sorrow shalt thou eat of it all the days of thy life.... In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat, till thou⁸ return unto the ground; for out of it wast thou taken: for dust thou art, and dust shalt thou return.⁶

⁴ Ibid., pp. 241-243

⁵ The publication in 1962 of the translation into English of Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit* (*Being and Time*, translated by John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson, New York: Harper & Row, 1962) is for the English-speaking world a philosophical event of the first order.

⁶ Genesis 3.

This passage is full of suggestions precisely for the sort of ontological analytic of man that Heidegger would delight in. the passage can be easily purged of any special mythological-theological overtones or interpretations arising from the "cursing" of "the ground" and the "eating in sorrow" and "in the sweat of thy face," as well as from the other imagery used; when thus purged, the passage would clearly reveal the pure phenomenological notion of care (Sorge) in the Heideggerian sense. although the Psalms do not purport to be a systematic-philosophical treatise on the ontology of man, and although David was not trained in the techniques of descriptive phenomenology nor steeped in the Kantian critical-transcendental method of uncovering the *a priori* "conditions of the possibility of a thing," still the Psalms, rightly and correctly understood, are the greatest fundamental ontological-existential work ever written. They portray in the clearest and most authentic manner every possible existential mood and state of being into which man can fall. They provide all the necessary material for a complete ontological system. and not only this: if philosophical ontology, but its very nature and claims, is able to reveal, through the systematic disclosure of phenomenology, only those structures which belong "by nature" to human existence, and if, side by side with this disclosure, there is also at least an intimation of a genuine realm of transcendence, a realm which can only be pointed to from a distance but can never be penetrated by any ontology or any human reason, then the Psalms supply, not only material for a complete "natural" ontology, but much positive information about that realm of transcendence itself.

The Book of Job is another great ontological storehouse within the Western tradition; the material it yields on "the human condition," not only for the special interpretation of Christian theology, but precisely for the requirements of philosophical ontology, is virtually inexhaustible. The Books of Ecclesiastes and of the Proverbs contain marvelous ontological disclosures about man and his state. One may say that the basic theme of the New Testament is the conquest of death through death, the redemption of the finite by the infinite taking on the form of the finite, the overcoming of essential human limitation and corruption⁷ by the perfect and incorruptible deigning to become and converse with man. But on these, are more ontological-existential than these.

In face, what does the whole Bible purport itself to be? It purports itself to be the Word of God, in a sense to be responsibility determined by theology. But the God of the Bible is the *creator* of heaven and earth, of everything visible and invisible, and therefore certainly of man, whom, the Bible affirms, God created in a very deep sense in "his own likeness and image." now a whole tome, composed of scores of books, worked out by innumerable minds over the span of some twenty centuries; a tome whose explicit theme throughout is the ground of all existence, including above all human existence; a tome, moreover, written, not about "ideas" or "structures" or "phenomena" of existence, nor about the direct, immediate, personal existence of some philosopher, but about actual, existing, historical men and peoples, in their *actual, historical dealings* with the ground of their existence: such a book must obviously occupy a unique position in all the annals of ontology; it must serve as the fountainhead *par excellence* of all existential-ontological material.⁸

⁷ On the point that Heidegger's analytic makes no "ontical assertion about the 'corruption of human nature,' see Heidegger, *op. cit.*, p. 224. But our reference to the New Testament need not involve any "special theology" or doctrine of "sin and corruption"; we are here only saying that genuine ontological structures can be culled in abundance there.

⁸ Consider further the following passages from the Bible. These were certainly not written expressly to meet the needs of some speculative existential philosopher. They contain more material than what is "conceptually" proper only for ontology. But they help, together with hundreds of other passages that could also be cited, to exhibit the Bible as a fundamental mine of ontological suggestion:

"And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM." Exodus 3:14.

"Yet man is born unto trouble, as sparks fly upward." Job 5:7.

"Man that is born of a woman is of few days, and full of trouble." Job 14:1

II

Nothing would appear more incongruous than to introduce this book with this strange meditation on the human condition and the relations between Heidegger and the Bible. But apparent incongruity here is not the last word. We will therefore proceed to dispel it.

In Heideggerian terms, man is a struggling-caring being. In Biblical terms, man is a being estranged from the ground of his being; and because he is thus estranged, and he knows it, he desperately seeks that ground again. put in better terms still, man is a creature; but whereas all other visible creatures just obey and rise no fuss about it whatever, this particular creature, man, has developed a sort of misunderstanding, even a sort of quarrel, between himself and his creator; he therefore seeks to "settle" this quarrel, or, better, his creator himself has sought to "settle" it for him. While this quarrel, this "enmity," lasts, he can never have peace; and so long as he exists, it will last. The struggle for peace, then, is grounded in a much deeper and more original struggle. Man struggles for peace because he *is essentially* a struggling being. But for this original ontological-existential struggling, there would be peace; his struggling essence makes possible his struggle for peace. it is not that he is all happy and peaceful to start with, and then, turning around, he *finds*, as it were casually, that there is something the matter with the world (in his family, in his immediate environment, in his country, between the nations); and so he sets about reforming the world. It is not that he is descending from the peace of Mount Olympus to distribute peace upon the world. To start with, man exists in such a fashion that he *is not* at peace either with himself or with the ground of his being-struggling and caring, above everything else, for the integrity of his being. He is struggling for outward peace of his own soul. In all such struggles there is an aspect of "the blind leading the blind," of "physician heal thyself." Man is the struggle for peace, if he is serious about it, if he really knows what it is all about, can only take his task with a sense of humor, even with a certain measure of cynicism. That is why most diplomats smile: it is not hypocrisy- it is a sort of metaphysical awareness of the human impossibility of their task. Man must first put his own spiritual house in order before he can help to establish peace in the world; or, at least, he is completely reconciled to God. There is a fundamental Christian dogma which, if he is a Christian, can help him immensely in this regard: the dogma that the reconciliation is *already vicariously accomplished* for him. That ought, to some extent, to put his mind "at peace"; at least to the extent of releasing him to struggle, in all humility, as best he can, and with such means and material as he may command, for the peace of the world. The struggle for peace cannot be understood exactly for what it is until it is viewed as an aspect of a much deeper struggle in the very being of man.

Now, some of the most creative minds of the West are trying to think out their ontology independently of the fountainhead of all ontology, a fountainhead which is at the base of all Western existence. This is a most significant phenomenon. These minds appear to be ashamed to face their existence; they seem embarrassed by it; somehow, they do not feel "free" in its presence. In the name of the autonomy of reason, they develop a view of human existence which is quite divorced from the actual, historical ground of that existence. There is something artificial, something even superficial and pathetic, in this attempt. It seeks existence and integrality with passion and singleness of mind, but there is about it a shying from, a disowning, even an ingratitude for, the ground of all existence. What is the ultimate reason for this secularizing and humanizing, this de-theologizing, de-spiritualizing and de-Christianizing,

"For what hath man of all his labour, and of the vexation of his heart, wherein he hath laboured under the sun? For all his days are sorrows, and his travail grief; yea, his heart taketh not rest in the night." Ecclesiastes 2:22-23.

"That which hath been is names already, and it is known that it is man." Ecclesiastes 6:10.

"Man is like to vanity: his days are as a shadow that passeth away." Psalm 144:4

"For we know that the whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now." Romans 8:22.

tendency? May it not have something to do with the sort of being that man is—a being who does get ashamed of his cause and ground, a being that recognizes his ground by rebelling against it, or even by maintaining a golden silence about it? Why this shame? Why this ingratitude? Why this disowning? Why this silence? It could have arisen from the suffering of two wars. A deeper struggle than any that has been noted so far appears to be called for here to overcome this disowning shame, and therewith to try to re-establish harmony and peace between man and his ground. Whether in this deeper struggle man can re-establish this harmony and peace on his own is of course the perennial question.

This phenomenon extends far beyond the confines of contemporary existential philosophy' in face, this philosophy itself is rooted in the radical existential estrangement pervading the spirit of this age. atheism is fundamentally only a rebellion against the real, living, historical "ground." the entire tone, the fundamental orientation, of present-day existence—political, social, literary, artistic, scientific, philosophical, cultural— is secular, nonreligious, even anti-religious and atheistic. "there is" the material world with its vast resources; "there is" man, however its powers are interpreted: *that is all*. Man and the world between themselves are absolutely self-sufficient; man needs absolutely nothing outside his possibilities to master the world, including of course himself and others. No wonder people talk of a "post-Christian" age, although their spirit is more to welcome and confirm than to regret and combat this tendency. We face therefore the phenomenon, in the practical-historical-cultural sphere, of the pride of existence and of human self-sufficiency. Man proudly refuses to acknowledge his ground, his origin, his dependence, and to draw the shattering consequences that that acknowledgment entails. so long as this radical existential pride holds sway, not only is individuals here and there, but in the fundamental direction and tone of a whole epoch, can any thinking man, with a broken and contrite heart, really expect any peace on earth?

We thus raise the question as to whether the peace that is sought after and struggled for under such conditions is not elusive; whether man is not only deluding himself when he thinks that through pride, cleverness, and self-sufficiency he can attain peace; whether on the pure presupposition of reason, nature, man, and existence, peace is possible; whether under such conditions even the best will in the world avails; whether the struggle then is not in the end blind and hopeless; and whether, therefore, all that one is hoping to achieve is simply not to let the peace be disturbed through him and in his time. He says in his heart: The thing is hopeless, so let me at least not be responsible myself; let whoever comes after me take responsibility for *the thing* himself. In all diplomatic, political, and international existence, there is a point at which the phenomenon if "passing the buck" is bound to manifest itself. How can man, forsaking his origin, disowning his ground, hugging himself alone, ever attain peace? Peace is some kind of harmony and order, a species of equilibrium and tranquility, a form of justice; but when man, either willfully or misguidedly, turns his back on his creative origin, is he any longer sure that there is much harmony and order, much equilibrium, tranquility and justice, left in him?

Let there be no misunderstanding on one point: Man will certainly keep on struggling-struggling for the highest prize, which is certainly peace. Man will struggle with the utmost sincerity and good faith, and with everything he has and is. He will achieve whatever measure of peace is humanly possible. no war at any time is altogether inevitable; something could always happen—and through human agency it could be made to happen—that could prevent, or at least that could postpone, any war. Thus, one will never relent in working day and night for the cause of peace. Nothing could be more noble. but let the slightest germ of doubt enter his head that on account of his pride, his self-sufficiency, his willful disowning of his origin and his ground, and his self-congratulation and self-satisfaction he has at last "caught" his existence and displayed it all by himself, the peace he seeks with such a spirit and under such a aegis is altogether false and illusory, and the deepest sadness will overtake his heart. He is no longer sure of himself. His whole attempt is vitiated at the core. He appears to himself beaten in advance. The greatest goal in the world—peace—is then revealed a veritable mirage, resting on insecure foundations. He appears

silly in his own eyes. His self-respect and his sense of seriousness become undermined. A dislocation assails his being. The 'struggle' appears quite hypocritical- in the final analysis, without hope. One indulges in it as a game, really sporting with destiny; it is not the real thing. Although you will never fail an occasion when it presents itself, you somehow know that you are engaged in a patching-up operation. You may have helped in averting this war, and you may with justice feel profound satisfaction, saying to yourself: That is all I can do, let others now do their part. But you know that that is not enough; for you are not seeking only your own glory, or that the world should applaud you for having "saved the peace." or that you should then merit the Nobel Prize. You are interested in something much more profound and much more serious. You really want to know whether lasting peace is possible; for a non-lasting peace is clearly not peace. You are asking about the nature and essence and possibility of peace. for although you have done your best and saved it this time, how can it last if human passion continues to take its own course, unpurged and uncontrolled? How can it last if man is such that self-love (Augustine) is the ultimate principle by which he is governed? Must you not then leave aside all your hypocrisy, all your sporting, all your patching up, all your struggling for peace, in order to enter into a new sphere of struggle altogether- the struggle for coming to terms with, and getting hold of, the mystery of your own nature and being and ground?

there is something at once necessary and noble, and false and sad, about the struggle for peace: necessary, because caring-free man must struggle; noble, because the struggle here is for the greatest prize; but false, because man is struggling in his own power; and, therefore, sad, because he know that such a struggle, for all its heroic and noble necessity, is doomed in the end to tragic failure.

"The peacemakers shall be called the children of God." nothing from the point of view of our discussion could be more strange and significant than this statement. It is full of ontological meat. It affirms that there is a direct relationship between peacemaking and having the right relationship to God- the ground of being and existence. It implies that you cannot make peace if you violate this right relationship. All struggling for peace where this relationship is broken is therefore false and futile. A proud and self-sufficient being, turning his back on his ground and origin, can never make peace. Western civilization, in dislocating itself from its source and creator, is not in the best position to make and secure peace.

III

Men struggle for peace on a thousand fronts. One such arena is the United Nations. Here the peace meant is "international peace and security": the absence of armed conflict between the nations as well as "the development of friendly relations" among them. from the moment Secretary Stettinius banged the gavel on April 25, 1945, opening the San Francisco Conference on International Organization, to the moment almost exactly fourteen years later when I, in my capacity then as President of the General Assembly of the United Nations, banged the gavel in New York closing the Assembly's Thirteenth Session, I had close and almost uninterrupted relations, in one form or another, with the United Nations. it was my privilege during this period, in addition to doing many other things, both to represent the Republic of Lebanon on delegations to many United Nations organs and to serve as an elected officer of many of its bodies. Besides being continuous, my experience at the United Nations was most inner, intimate, and intense. The first part of this book contains but the barest and most preliminary sketch of some of my existential conclusions from this experience. the individual human person here is struggling always with a view to bringing about some understanding, some concord, some "realization of tensions," some positive agreement between nations; not indeed at any price, but under the guidance and with the determination of some notion of justice, as embodied principally in recognized international law and in the Charter of the United Nations. But above both Charter and law, the most decisive element is the living agreement of free

agents. When there is a dispute or a conflict or even war, and when the parties concerned freely agree to some settlement, the agreement is itself the law and the charter of that situation. Once an agreement is reached, and however it is reached, nobody thinks any more of the United Nations, of international law, or even of justice. The parties concerned are now quite satisfied, and that is the end of the matter so far as "international peace and security" are concerned. There is no law or power above the will of the parties concerned; this is another way of saying that they enjoy the status of "sovereign equality." International law and the Charter of the United Nations serve only as general frameworks for promoting and inducing that agreement. *Peace* in the international field is in the end nothing but agreement. United Nations is therefore *how to bring about agreement*. Man in the struggle for peace at the United Nations is precisely a slave of this regulative idea.

What happens now to this poor or happy man? How does he give effect to this regulative idea? What modes of being does he get himself into? What does he concretely go through? What does he "come up against," both in himself and in the world? Through what passions, what tendencies, what forces, what actual organized movements, must he thread his path? How much is he personally "compromised" in the process? He is at once a representative of a certain national interest and a responsible member of the world body; how do these two loyalties, his national citizenship and his world citizenship, interact? When he is elated, what elates him? When he is depressed and disgusted, what depresses and disgusts him? What is the rock on which he rests in his darkest and loneliest moments?

What is it that keeps him going? Ambition? Vanity? Flattery? Glory? Pure chance? Sheer doggedness? The glamour of the show? The simple fact that he has a good "job"? The service he is rendering his nation? The love of international concord? The lure of justice? The wonderful experiences he undergoes? The fact that others "need" him and have entrusted him with important responsibilities? The compelling nature of the prospect of peace? The pure inner satisfaction that he is a faithful soldier in the battle for peace?

What is it in "the constitution of his personal human existence" that makes possible his international role? His rational being? His sense of human brotherhood? A certain cosmopolitan-international background in his education and upbringing? His fear that war would destroy him and his loved ones? The thrill of taking risks and of danger and adventure? A special weakness for the material, social, and political benefits enjoyed? An original inexplicable, irreducible, special, personal interest in matters international? A special devil (*daimon*) dogging him on?

Does man in his international struggling today differ existentially from man struggling internationally at any time in history, when, for instance, the Spartans sent embassies to the Athenians, or the Athenians to the Romans, or the Byzantines to the Arab caliphs, or when statesmen forgathered at the Congress of Vienna or at the Paris Peace Conference of 1919? What does this constancy of human nature mean? Is not the doctrine of progress, then, a sort of escape from this constancy, a sort of childish wishfulness that it did not exist?

I and Thou

Martin Buber

The world is twofold for man in accordance with his twofold attitude.

The attitude of man is twofold in accordance with the two basic words he can speak.

The basic words are not single words but word pairs.

One basic word is the word pair I-You.

The other basic word is the word-pair I-It; but this basic word is not changed when He or She takes the place of It.

Thus the I of man is also twofold.

For the I of the basic word I-You is different from that in the basic word I-It.⁹

Basic words do not state something that might exist outside them; by being spoken they establish a mode of existence.¹⁰

Basic words are spoken with one's being.¹¹

When one says You, the I of the word pair I-You is said, too.

When one says It, the I of the word pair I-It is said, too.

The basic word I-You can only be spoken with one's whole being.

There is no I as such but only the I of the basic word I-You and the I of the basic word I-It.

When a man says I, he means one or the other. The I he means is present when he says I. And he when he says You or It, the I of one of the other basic word is also present.

Being I and saying I are the same. Saying I and saying one of the two basic words are the same.

Whoever speaks one of the basic words enters into the word and stands in it.

The life of a human being does not exist merely in the sphere of goal-directed verbs. It does not consist merely of activities that have something for their object.

I perceive something. I feel something. I imagine something. I want something. I sense something. I think something. The life of a human being does not consist merely of all this and its like.

All this and its like is the basis of the realm of the It.

But the realm of You has another basis.

⁹ In the first section the next section began: "Basic words do not signify things but relations." This sentence was omitted by Buber in 1957 and in all subsequent editions.

¹⁰ *stiften sie einen Bestand*. The locution is most unusual, and *Bestand* in any applicable sense is very rare. Buber intends a contrast with "that might exist" (*was...bestünde*.)

¹¹ *Wesen*: see page 46.

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Whoever says You does not have something for his object. For wherever there is something there is also another something; every It borders on other Its; It is only by virtue of bordering on others. But where You is said there is no something. You has no borders.

Whoever says You does not have something; he has nothing. But he stands in relation

* * *

We are told that man experiences his world. What does this mean?

Man goes over the surfaces of things and experiences them.¹² He brings back from them some knowledge of their condition—an experience. He experiences what there is to things.

But it is not experiences alone that bring the world to man.

For what they bring to him is only a world that consists of It and It, of He and He and She and It.

I experience something.

All this is not changed by adding "inner" experiences to the "external" ones, in line with the non-external distinction that is born of mankind's craving to take the edge off the mystery of death. Inner things like external things, things among things!

I experience something.

And all this is not changed by adding "mysterious" experiences to "manifest" ones, self-confident in the wisdom that recognizes a secret compartment in things, reserved for the initiated, and holds the key. O mysteriousness without mystery, O piling up of information! It, it, it!

* * *

Those who experience do not participate in the world. For the experience is "in them" and not between them and the world.

The world does not participate in experience. It allows itself to be experienced, but it is not concerned, for it contributes nothing, and nothing happens to it.

* * *

The world as experience belongs to the basic word I-It.

The basic word I-You establishes the world of relation.

Three are the spheres¹³ in which the world of relation arises.

¹² *Der Mensch befährt die Fläche der Dinge und erfährt sie.* Both *erfährt* in this sentence and *erfahre* in the preceding paragraph are forms of *erfahren*, the ordinary German equivalent of the verb, to experience. The noun is *Erfahrung*. These words are so common that it has hardly ever occurred to anyone that they are closely related to *fahren*, an equally familiar word that means to drive or go. *Befahren* means to drive over the surface of something. The effect of the German sentence is to make the reader suddenly aware of the possibility that *erfahren* might literally mean finding out by going or driving, or possibly by traveling. But by further linking *erfahren* with *befahren* Buber manages to suggest that experience stays on the surface.

In the original manuscript this point was elaborated further in the sentence immediately following upon this paragraph; but Buber struck it out: "Thus the fisherman gets his catch. But the find is for the diver."

¹³ This locution echoes Passover Haggadah which contains a famous song in which each stanza begins: One is..., Two are..., Three are..., etc.

The first: life with nature. Here the relation vibrates in the dark and remains below language. The creatures stir across from us, but they are unable to come to us, and the You we say to them sticks to the threshold of language.

The second: life with men. Here the relation is manifest and enters language. We can give and receive the You.

The third: life with spiritual beings. Here the relation is wrapped in a cloud but reveals itself,¹⁴ it lacks but creates language. We hear no You and yet addressed; we answer—creating, thinking, acting: with our being we speak the basic word, unable to say You with our mouth.

But how can we incorporate into the world of the basic word that lies outside language?

In every sphere, through everything that becomes present to us, we gaze toward the train¹⁵ of the eternal You; in each we perceive a breath of it;¹⁶ in every You we address the eternal You, in every sphere according to its manner.

* * *

I contemplate a tree.

I can accept it as a picture: a rigid pillar in a flood of light, or splashes of green¹⁷ traversed by the gentleness of the blue silver ground.

I can feel it as movement: the flowing veins around the sturdy, striving core, the sucking of the roots, the breathing of the leaves, the infinite commerce with the earth and air—the growing itself in its darkness.

I can assign it to a species and observe it as an instance, with an eye to its construction and its way of life.

I can overcome its uniqueness and form so rigorously that I recognize it only as an expression of the law—those laws according to which a constant opposition of forces is continually adjusted, or those laws according to which the elements mix and separate.

I can dissolve it into a number, into a pure relation between numbers, and eternalize it. Throughout all of this the tree remains my object and has its place and its time span, its kind and condition.

But it can also happen, if will and grace are joined, that as I contemplate the tree I am drawn into a relation, and tree ceases to be an It. The power of exclusiveness has seized me.

This does not require me to forego any of the modes of contemplation. There is nothing that I must see in order to see, and there is no knowledge that I must forget. Rather is everything, picture and movement, species and instance, law and number included and inseparably fused.

Whatever belongs to the tree is included: its form and its mechanics, its colors and its chemistry, its conversation with the elements and its conversation with the stars—all that in its entirety.

The tree is no impression, no play of my imagination, no aspect of a mood; it confronts me bodily¹⁸ and has to deal with me as I must deal with it—only differently.

¹⁴ *Sich offenbarend*. A few lines earlier, *offenbar* was translated as manifest. The adjective, unlike the verb, generally has no religious overtones.

¹⁵ *Saum* means hem or edge, but this is surely an allusion to Isaiah 6:1.

¹⁶ *Wehen*: literally, blowing (of a breeze or wind), wafting.

¹⁷ *Das spritzende Gegrün*: the noun is coinage.

¹⁸ *Er leibt mir gegenüber*. . . *Leib* means body; *leibt* is most unusual and means literally: it bodies—across from me or vis-a-vis me. Locutions that involve *gegenüber* abound in this book. A few lines below, in the first sentence of the next section, we find *Stehe ich . . . gegenüber*; in the following section, *gegenübertritt* and *des Gegenüber* and—a variant—*entgengentritt*. Cf. p. 45.

One should not try to dilute the meaning of the relation: relation is reciprocity. Does the tree then have consciousness, similar to our own? I have no experience of that. But thinking that you have brought this off in your own case, must you again divide the indivisible? What I encounter is neither the soul of a tree nor a dryad, but the tree itself.

* * *

When I confront a human being as my You and speak the basic word I-You to him, then he is no thing among things nor does he consist of things.

He is no longer He or She, limited by other Hes and Shes, a dot in the world grid of space and time, nor a condition that can be experienced and described, a loose bundle of named qualities. Neighborless and seamless, he is you and fills the firmament. Not as if there was nothing but he; but everything else lives in *his* light.

Even as a melody is not composed of tones, nor a verse of words, nor a statue of lines—one must pull and tear to turn a unity into a multiplicity—so it is with the human being to whom I say You. I can abstract from him the color of his hair or the color of his speech or the color of his graciousness; I have to do this again and again; but immediately he is no longer You.

And even as prayer is not in time but time in prayer, the sacrifice not in space but space in sacrifice—and whoever reverse the relation annuls the reality—I do not find the human being to whom I say in any Sometime and Somewhere. I can place him there and have to do this again and again, but immediately he becomes a He or a She, an It, and no longer remains my You.

As long as the firmament of the You is spread over me, the tempests of causality cower at my heels, and the whirl of doom¹⁹ congeals.

The human being to whom I say You I do not experience. But I stand in relation to him, in the sacred basic word. Only when I step out of this to I experience him again. Experience is remoteness from You.

The relation can obtain even if the human being to whom I say You does not hear it in his experience. For You is more than It knows. You does more, and more happens to it, than It knows. No deception reaches this far: here is the cradle of actual life.

* * *

This is the eternal origin of art that a human being confronts a form that wants to become a work through him. Not a figment of his soul but something that appears to the soul and demands the soul's creative power. What is required is a deed that a man does with his whole being: if he commits it and speaks with his being the basic word²⁰ to the form that appears, then the creative power is released and the work comes into being.

The deed involves a sacrifice and a risk. The sacrifice: infinite possibility is surrendered on the altar of the form; all that but a moment ago floated playfully through one's perspective has to be exterminated;

¹⁹ *Verhängnis* means, and has been consistently translated as, doom; *Schicksal*, as fate.

²⁰ *Es kommt auf eine Wesenstat des Menschen an: vollzieht er sie, spricht er mit seinem Wesen das Grundwort...* Henceforth, *Wesenstat* and *Wesensakt* are translated "essential deed" and "essential act": but the meaning that is intended is spelled out here.

"Form": *Gestalt*. One might consider leaving this word untranslated because *Gestalt* has become familiar in English; but the associations of Gestalt psychology might be more distracting than helpful, but *Gestaltung* (below: "forming") needs to be translated in any case.

none of it may penetrate into the work; the exclusiveness of such a confrontation demands this. The risk: the basic word can only be spoken with one's whole being; whoever commits himself may not hold back part of himself; and the work does not permit me, as a tree or man might, to seek relaxation in the It-world; it is imperious: if I do not serve it properly, it breaks, or it breaks me.

The form that confronts me I cannot experience nor describe; I can only actualize it. And yet I see it, radiant in the splendor of the confrontation, far more clearly than all clarity of the experienced world. Not as a thing among the "internal" things, not as a figment of the "imagination." But as which is present. Tested for its objectivity, the form is not "there" at all; but what can equality its presence? And it is an actual relation: it acts on me as I act on it.²¹

Such work is creation, inventing is finding.²² Forming is discovery. As I actualize, I uncover. I lead the form across—into the world of It. The created work is a thing among things and can be experienced and described as an aggregate of qualities. But the receptive beholder²³ may be bodily confronted now and then.

* * *

--What, then, does one experience of the You?

--Nothing at all. For one does not experience it.

--What, then, does one know of the You?

--Only everything. For one no longer knows particulars.

* * *

The You encounters me by grace—it cannot be found by seeking. But that I speak the basic word to it is a deed by my whole being, is my essential deed.

The You encounters me. But I enter into a direct relationship to it. Thus the relationship is election and electing, passive and active at once: An action of the whole being must approach passivity, for it does away with all partial actions and thus with any sense of action, which depends on limited exertions.

The basic word I-You can be spoken only with one's whole being. The concentration and fusion into a whole being. The concentration and fusion into a whole being can never be accomplished without me. I require a You to become; becoming I, I say You.

All actual life is encounter.

* * *

The relation to the You is unmediated.²⁴ Nothing conceptual intervenes between I and You, no prior knowledge and no imagination; and memory itself is changed as it plunges from particularity into

²¹ Actual: *wirklich*; acts: *wirkt*; act: *wirke*. Earlier in the same paragraph, actualize: *verwicklichen*. In English "real" and "realize" would sometimes be smoother than "actual" and "actualize"; but it is noteworthy that the German word *wirklich* is so closely associated, not only by Buber but also by Nietzsche and Goethe before him, with *wirken*, *Werk* (work), *Wirkung* (effect), and *wirksam* (effective). Cf. p. 45f.

²² *Schaffen ist Schöpfen, Erfinden ist Finden*. *Schaffen* can mean to work or to create; *schöpfen* means to create. *Erfinden* is the ordinary German word for invent, and *finden* means to find.

²³ *Dem...Schauenden*. *Schauen* is a way of looking that in this book is not associated with experiencing, with objects, with It. It has generally been translated "behold."

²⁴ *Unmittelbar* is the ordinary German word for the immediate. *Mittel* is the ordinary word for means (the noun, both in contrast of means and ends and also in the sense of being without means). This noun is encountered in the last two sentences of this

wholeness. No purpose intervenes between I and You, no greed and no anticipation; and longing itself is changed as it plunges from the dream into appearance. Every means is an obstacle. Only where all means have disintegrated encounters occur.

* * *

Before the immediacy of the relationship everything mediate becomes negligible. It is also trifling whether my You is the It of the other I's ("object of general experience") or can only become that as a result of my essential deed. For the real boundary, albeit one that floats and fluctuates, runs not between experience and non-experience, nor between the given and the not-given, nor between the world of being and world of value, but across all the regions between You and It: between presence and object.²⁵

* * *

The present—not that which is like a point and merely designates whatever our thoughts may posit as the end of "elapsed" time, the fiction of the fixed lapse, but the actual and fulfilled present—exists only insofar as presentness, encounter, and relation exist. Only as the You becomes present does presence come into being.

The I of the basic I-It, the I that is not bodily confronted by a You²⁶ but surrounded by a multitude of "contents," has only a past and no present. In other words: insofar as a human being makes do with the things that he experiences and uses, he lives in the past, and his moment has no presence. He has nothing but objects; but objects consist in having been.

Presence is not what is evanescent and passes but what confronts us, waiting and enduring.²⁷ And the object is not duration but standing still, ceasing, breaking off, becoming rigid, standing out, the lack of relation, the lack of presence.

What is essential is lived in the present, objects²⁸ in the past.

paragraph. In the first sentence of the following paragraph Buber contrasts *Unmittelbarkeit* and *alles Mittelbare*. In the present context it seemed feasible and important to reproduce this counterpoint of concepts in English, but elsewhere *unmittelbar* has often been translated as direct. While this word is positive and *unmittelbar* is negative, "direct" suggests more forcibly the absence of any intermediary than does "immediate" with its primarily temporal connotations.

²⁵ *Gegenwart und Gegenstand*: this contrast is developed and echoed in the following sections. The words are discussed on p.45: *Gegenwart* means both the presence and the present as opposed to past and future; and in the next sentence it has been translated "the present."

²⁶ See note I on page 58.

²⁷ *Gegenwart ist...das Gegenwartende und Gengenwährende*. The first word is the usual term for the present or presence, the other two capitalized words are coinages and represent plays on the first word.

²⁸ *Wesenheiten werden in der Gegenwart gelebt, Gegenständlichkeiten in der Vergangenheit*. This is an extraordinary sentence. Both *Wesenheit* and *Gegenständlichkeit* are rare words with no very precise meaning: the effect of the suffixes (*heit* and *keit*) is to add a note of abstractness and generality, comparable to "essencehood" and "objecthood." Using these two words in the plural is most unusual, and saying that the former is lived in the present and the latter in the past is a *tour de force*. In German, as in English, only life can "be lived." Had Buber said *erlebt* (experienced in a living or vital manner), the sentence would be much less puzzling; but in this book he treats experience (*erfahrung*) as a corollary of object and It, and generally he does not exempt *Erlebnis* which, though more vital and intense, suggests an aesthetic orientation. The last half of the sentence is much less difficult than the first. We have been prepared for it by the two preceding paragraphs; e.g., "objects consist in having been." Whatever is not present to me and—to use my own expression—addressing me as a person, whatever is remembered, discussed, or analyzed, has lapsed into the past and is an object.

"Beings are lived in the present" does not make much sense of the first six words, although *Wesen* in this book means being or nature more often than it means essence. Beings simply are not lived; they live, they may address us and change our lives, but to say that they are lived is not merely a solecism but contrary to what Buber says in this book. "What is essential is lived in the

This essential twofoldness cannot be overcome by invoking a "world of ideas" as a third element that might transcend this opposition. For I speak only of the actual human being, of you and me, of our life and our world, not of any I-in-itself and not of any Being-in-itself. But for an actual human being the real boundary also runs across the world of ideas.

To be sure, some men who in the world of things make do with experiencing and using have constructed for themselves an idea annex or superstructure in which they find refuge and reassurance in the face of intimations of nothingness. At the threshold they take off clothes of the ugly weekday, shroud themselves in clean garments, and feel restored as they contemplate primal being or what ought to be—something in which their life has no share. It may also make them feel good to proclaim it.

But the It-humanity that some imagine, postulate, and advertise has nothing in common with the bodily humanity to which a human being can truly say You. The noblest fiction is a fetish, the most sublime fictitious sentiment is a vice. The ideas are just as little enthroned above our heads as they reside inside them; they walk among us and step up to us. Pitiful are those who leave the basic word unspoken, but wretched are those who instead of that address the ideas with a concept or a slogan as if that were their name!

* * *

That direct relationships involve more action on²⁹ what confronts us becomes clear in one of three examples. The essential deed of art determines the process whereby the form becomes a work. That which confronts me is fulfilled through the encounter through which it enters into the world of things in order to remain incessantly effective, incessantly It—but also infinitely able to become again a You, enchanting and inspiring. It becomes "incarnate": out of the flood of spaceless and timeless presence it rises to the shore of continued existence.³⁰

* * *

Less clear is the element of action in relation to a human You. The essential act that here establishes directness is usually understood as a feeling, and thus misunderstood. Feelings accompany the metaphysical and metaphysical fact of love, but they do not constitute it; and the feelings that accompany it can be very different. Jesus' feeling for the possessed man is different from his feeling for the beloved disciple; but the love is one. Feeling one "has"; love occurs. Feelings dwell in man, but man dwells in his love. This is no metaphor, but an actuality: love does not cling to an I, as if the You were merely its "content" or object; it is between I and You. Whoever does not know this, know this with his being, does not know love, even if he should ascribe to it the feelings that he lives through,³¹ experiences, enjoys, and expresses. Love is a cosmic force.³² For those who stand in it and behold in it, men emerge from their entanglement in busy-ness;³³ and the good and the evil, the clever and the foolish, the beautiful and the ugly, one after another become actual and a You for them; that is, liberated, emerging into a unique

present" is linguistically not so outrageous, is much more meaningful, and suggests an idea that is in keeping with the central motifs of this book.

²⁹ *Ein Wirken an*: an odd locution.

³⁰ *Das Ufer des Bestands*: see page 53, note 2

³¹ *Erlebt*.

³² *Liebe ist ein welthaftes Wirken*.

³³ *Getriebe*.

confrontation.³⁴ Exclusiveness comes into being miraculously again and again—and now one can act, help, heal, educate, raise, redeem. Love is responsibility of an I for a You: in this consists what cannot consist in any feeling—the equality of all lovers, from the smallest to the greatest and from the blissfully secure whose life is circumscribed by the life of one beloved human being to him that is nailed his life long to the cross of the world, capable of what is immense and bold enough to risk it, to love *man*.³⁵

* * *

Let the meaning of action in the third example, that of the creature and its contemplation, remain mysterious. Believe in the simple magic of life, in service of the universe, and it will dawn on you what this waiting, peering, "stretching of the neck"³⁶ of the creature means. Every word must falsify; but look, these beings live around you, and no matter which one you approach you always reach Being.³⁷

* * *

Relation is reciprocity. My You acts on me as I act on it. Our students teach us, our works form us. The "wicked" become a revelation when they are touched by the sacred basic word. How are we educated by children, by animals! Inscrutably involved, we live in the currents of universal reciprocity.

* * *

--You speak of love as if it were the only relationship between men; but are you even justified in choosing in it as an example, seeing that there is also hatred?
--As long as love is "blind"—that is, as long as it does not see a *whole* being—it does not yet truly stand under...

³⁴ *Herausgetreten, einzeln und gegenüber wesend.*

³⁵ *die Menschen zu lieben.*

³⁶ Since 1957: "stretching the head forward." Surely, we are to think of a cat: see pp. 1144 ff.

³⁷ *die Wesen leben um dich herum...du kommst immer zum Wesen.* In another context many translators would, no doubt, render *die Wesen* by "the creatures" and *zum Wesen* by "the essence." That way something important would be lost, but these meanings are present.

Men Without Chests

C.S. Lewis

So he sent the word to slay
And slew the little childer.

-Traditional Carol

I doubt whether we are sufficiently attentive to the importance of elementary text books. That is why I have chosen as the starting-point for these lectures a little book on English intended for 'boys and girls in the upper forms of schools'. I do not think the authors of this book (there were two of them) intended any harm, and I owe them, or their publisher, good language for sending me a complimentary copy. At the same time I shall have nothing good to say of them. Here is a pretty predicament. I do not want to pillory two modest practising schoolmasters who were doing the best they knew: but I cannot be silent about what I think the actual tendency of their work. I therefore propose to conceal their names. I shall refer to these gentlemen as Gaius and Titius and to their book as *The Green Book*. But I promise you there is such a book and I have it on my shelves.

In their second chapter Gaius and Titius quote the well-known story of Coleridge at the waterfall. You remember that there were two tourists present: that one called it 'sublime' and the other 'pretty'; and that Coleridge mentally endorsed the first judgement and rejected the second with disgust. Gaius and Titius comment as follows: 'When the man said *This is sublime*, he appeared to be making a remark about the waterfall... Actually ... he was not making a remark about the waterfall, but a remark about his own feelings. What he was saying was really *I have feelings associated in my mind with the word "Sublime"*, or shortly, *I have sublime feelings*' Here are a good many deep questions settled in a pretty summary fashion. But the authors are not yet finished. They add: 'This confusion is continually present in language as we use it. We appear to be saying something very important about something: and actually we are only saying something about our own feelings.'¹

Before considering the issues really raised by this momentous little paragraph (designed, you will remember, for 'the upper forms of schools') we must eliminate one mere confusion into which Gaius and Titius have fallen. Even on their own view—on any conceivable view—the man who says *This is sublime* cannot mean *I have sublime feelings*. Even if it were granted that such qualities as sublimity were simply and solely projected into things from our own emotions, yet the emotions which prompt the projection are the correlatives, and therefore almost the opposites, of the qualities projected. The feelings which make a man call an object sublime are not sublime feelings but feelings of veneration. If *This is sublime* is to be reduced at all to a statement about the speaker's feelings, the proper translation would be *I have humble feelings*. If the view held by Gaius and Titius were consistently applied it would lead to obvious absurdities. It would force them to maintain that *You are contemptible* means *I have contemptible feelings*; in fact that *Your feelings are contemptible* means *My feelings are contemptible*. But we need not delay over this which is the very *pons asinorum* of our subject. It would be unjust to Gaius and Titius themselves to emphasize what was doubtless a mere inadvertence.

The schoolboy who reads this passage in *The Green Book* will believe two propositions: firstly, that all sentences containing a predicate of value are statements about the emotional state of the speaker, and secondly, that all such statements are unimportant. It is true that Gaius and Titius have said neither of these things in so many words. They have treated only one particular predicate of value (*sublime*) as a word descriptive of the speaker's emotions. The pupils are left to do for themselves the work of extending

¹ *The Green Book*, pp. 19, 20

the same treatment to all predicates of value: and no slightest obstacle to such extension is placed in their way. The authors may or may not desire the extension: they may never have given the question five minutes' serious thought in their lives. I am not concerned with what they desired but with the effect their book will certainly have on the schoolboy's mind. In the same way, they have not said that judgements of value are unimportant. Their words are that we '*appear* to be saying something very important' when in reality we are '*only* saying something about our own feelings'. No schoolboy will be able to resist the suggestion brought to bear upon him by that word *only*. I do not mean, of course, that he will make any conscious inference from what he reads to a general philosophical theory that all values are subjective and trivial. The very power of Gaius and Titius depends on the fact that they are dealing with a boy: a boy who thinks he is 'doing' his 'English prep' and has no notion that ethics, theology, and politics are all at stake. It is not a theory they put into his mind, but an assumption, which ten years hence, its origin forgotten and its presence unconscious, will condition him to take one side in a controversy which he has never recognized as a controversy at all. The authors themselves, I suspect, hardly know what they are doing to the boy, and he cannot know what is being done to him.

Before considering the philosophical credentials of the position which Gaius and Titius have adopted about value, I should like to show its practical results on the educational procedure. In their fourth chapter they quote a silly advertisement of a pleasure cruise and proceed to inoculate their pupils against the sort of writing it exhibits.² The advertisement tells us that those who buy tickets for this cruise will go 'across the Western Ocean where Drake of Devon sailed', 'adventuring after the treasures of the Indies', and bringing home themselves also a 'treasure' of 'golden hours' and 'glowing colours'. It is a bad bit of writing, of course: a venal and bathetic exploitation of those emotions of awe and pleasure which men feel in visiting places that have striking associations with history or legend. If Gaius and Titius were to stick to their last and teach their readers (as they promised to do) the art of English composition, it was their business to put this advertisement side by side with passages from great writers in which the very emotion is well expressed, and then show where the difference lies.

They might have used Johnson's famous passage from the *Western Islands*, which concludes: 'That man is little to be envied, whose patriotism would not gain force upon the plain of Marathon, or whose piety would not grow warmer among the ruins of Iona.'³ They might have taken that place in *The Prelude* where Wordsworth describes how the antiquity of London first descended on his mind with 'Weight and power, Power growing under weight'.⁴ A lesson which had laid such literature beside the advertisement and really discriminated the good from the bad would have been a lesson worth teaching. There would have been some blood and sap in it—the trees of knowledge and of life growing together. It would also have had the merit of being a lesson in literature: a subject of which Gaius and Titius, despite their professed purpose, are uncommonly shy.

What they actually do is to point out that the luxurious motor-vessel won't really sail where Drake did, that the tourists will not have any adventures, that the treasures they bring home will be of a purely metaphorical nature, and that a trip to Margate might provide 'all the pleasure and rest' they required.⁵ All this is very true: talents inferior to those of Gaius and Titius would have sufficed to discover it. What they have not noticed, or not cared about, is that a very similar treatment could be applied to much good literature which treats the same emotion. What, after all, can the history of early British Christianity, in pure reason, add to the motives for piety as they exist in the eighteenth century? Why should Mr Wordsworth's inn be more comfortable or the air of London more healthy because London has existed for

² Ibid, p 53

³ *Journey to the Western Islands* (Samuel Johnson).

⁴ *The Prelude*, viii, ll. 549-59.

⁵ *The Green Book*, pp. 53-5.

a long time? Or, if there is indeed any obstacle which will prevent a critic from 'debunking' Johnson and Wordsworth (and Lamb, and Virgil, and Thomas Browne, and Mr de la Mare) as *The Green Book* debunks the advertisement, Gaius and Titius have given their schoolboy readers no faintest help to its discovery.

From this passage the schoolboy will learn about literature precisely nothing. What he will learn quickly enough, and perhaps indelibly, is the belief that all emotions aroused by local association are in themselves contrary to reason and contemptible. He will have no notion that there are two ways of being immune to such an advertisement—that it falls equally flat on those who are above it and those who are below it, on the man of real sensibility and on the mere trousered ape who has never been able to conceive the Atlantic as anything more than so many million tons of cold salt water. There are two men to whom we offer in vain a false leading article on patriotism and honour: one is the coward, the other is the honourable and patriotic man. None of this is brought before the schoolboy's mind. On the contrary, he is encouraged to reject the lure of the 'Western Ocean' on the very dangerous ground that in so doing he will prove himself a knowing fellow who can't be bubbled out of his cash. Gaius and Titius, while teaching him nothing about letters, have cut out of his soul, long before he is old enough to choose, the possibility of having certain experiences which thinkers of more authority than they have held to be generous, fruitful, and humane. But it is not only Gaius and Titius. In another little book, whose author I will call Orbilius, I find that the same operation, under the same general anaesthetic, is being carried out. Orbilius chooses for 'debunking' a silly bit of writing on horses, where these animals are praised as the 'willing servants' of the early colonists in Australia.⁶ And he falls into the same trap as Gaius and Titius. Of Ruksh and Sleipnir and the weeping horses of Achilles and the war-horse in the Book of Job—nay even of Brer Rabbit and of Peter Rabbit—of man's prehistoric piety to 'our brother the ox'—of all that this semi-anthropomorphic treatment of beasts has meant in human history and of the literature where it finds noble or piquant expression—he has not a word to say.⁷ Even of the problems of animal psychology as they exist for science he says nothing. He contents himself with explaining that horses are not, *secundum litteram*, interested in colonial expansion.⁸ This piece of information is really all that his pupils get from him. Why the composition before them is bad, when others that lie open to the same charge are good, they do not hear. Much less do they learn of the two classes of men who are, respectively, above and below the danger of such writing—the man who really knows horses and really loves them, not with anthropomorphic illusions, but with ordinate love, and the irredeemable urban blockhead to whom a horse is merely an old-fashioned means of transport. Some pleasure in their own ponies and dogs they will have lost; some incentive to cruelty or neglect they will have received; some pleasure in their own knowingness will have entered their minds. That is their day's lesson in English, though of English they have learned nothing. Another little portion of the human heritage has been quietly taken from them before they were old enough to understand.

I have hitherto been assuming that such teachers as Gaius and Titius do not fully realize what they are doing and do not intend the far-reaching consequences it will actually have. There is, of course, another possibility. What I have called (presuming on their concurrence in a certain traditional system of values) the 'trousered ape' and the 'urban blockhead' may be precisely the kind of man they really wish to

⁶ Orbilius' book, p 5.

⁷ Orbilius is so far superior to Gaius and Titius that he does (pp. 19-22) contrast a piece of good writing to animals with the piece condemned. Unfortunately, however, the only superiority he really demonstrates in the second extract is its superiority in factual truth. The specifically literary problem (the use and abuse of expressions which are false *secundum litteram*) is not tackled. Orbilius indeed tells us (p. 97) that we must 'learn to distinguish between legitimate and illegitimate figurative statement', but he gives us very little help in doing so. At the same time it is fair to record my opinion that his work is on quite a different level from *The Green Book*.

⁸ Ibid, p 9.

produce. The differences between us may go all the way down. They may really hold that the ordinary human feelings about the past or animals or large waterfalls are contrary to reason and contemptible and ought to be eradicated. They may be intending to make a clean sweep of traditional values and start with a new set. That position will be discussed later. If it is the position which Gaius and Titius are holding, I must, for the moment, content myself with pointing out that it is a philosophical and not a literary position. In filling their book with it they have been unjust to the parent or headmaster who buys it and who has got the work of amateur philosophers where he expected the work of professional grammarians. A man would be annoyed if his son returned from the dentist with his teeth untouched and his head crammed with the dentist's *obiter dicta* on bimetallism or the Baconian theory.

But I doubt whether Gaius and Titius have really planned, under cover of teaching English, to propagate their philosophy. I think they have slipped into it for the following reasons. In the first place, literary criticism is difficult, and what they actually do is very much easier. To explain why a bad treatment of some basic human emotion is bad literature is, if we exclude all question-begging attacks on the emotion itself, a very hard thing to do. Even Dr Richards, who first seriously tackled the problem of badness in literature, failed, I think, to do it. To 'debunk' the emotion, on the basis of a commonplace rationalism, is within almost anyone's capacity. In the second place, I think Gaius and Titius may have honestly misunderstood the pressing educational need of the moment. They see the world around them swayed by emotional propaganda—they have learned from tradition that youth is sentimental—and they conclude that the best thing they can do is to fortify the minds of young people against emotion. My own experience as a teacher tells an opposite tale. For every one pupil who needs to be guarded from a weak excess of sensibility there are three who need to be awakened from the slumber of cold vulgarity. The task of the modern educator is not to cut down jungles but to irrigate deserts. The right defence against false sentiments is to inculcate just sentiments. By starving the sensibility of our pupils we only make them easier prey to the propagandist when he comes. For famished nature will be avenged and a hard heart is no infallible protection against a soft head.

But there is a third, and a profounder, reason for the procedure which Gaius and Titius adopt. They may be perfectly ready to admit that a good education should build some sentiments while destroying others. They may endeavour to do so. But it is impossible that they should succeed. Do what they will, it is the 'debunking' side of their work, and this side alone, which will really tell. In order to grasp this necessity clearly I must digress for a moment to show that what may be called the educational predicament of Gaius and Titius is different from that of all their predecessors.

Until quite modern times all teachers and even all men believed the universe to be such that certain emotional reactions on our part could be either congruous or incongruous to it—believed, in fact, that objects did not merely receive, but could *merit*, our approval or disapproval, our reverence or our contempt. The reason why Coleridge agreed with the tourist who called the cataract sublime and disagreed with the one who called it pretty was of course that he believed inanimate nature to be such that certain responses could be more 'just' or 'ordinate' or 'appropriate' to it than others. And he believed (correctly) that the tourists thought the same. The man who called the cataract sublime was not intending simply to describe his own emotions about it: he was also claiming that the object was one which *merited* those emotions. But for this claim there would be nothing to agree or disagree about. To disagree with *This is pretty* if those words simply described the lady's feelings, would be absurd: if she had said *I feel sick* Coleridge would hardly have replied *No; I feel quite well*. When Shelley, having compared the human sensibility to an Aeolian lyre, goes on to add that it differs from a lyre in having a power of 'internal adjustment' whereby it can 'accommodate its chords to the motions of that which strikes them',⁹ he is

⁹ *Defence of Poetry*.

assuming the same belief. 'Can you be righteous', asks Traherne, 'unless you be just in rendering to things their due esteem? All things were made to be yours and you were made to prize them according to their value.'¹⁰

St Augustine defines virtue as *ordo amoris*, the ordinate condition of the affections in which every object is accorded that kind of degree of love which is appropriate to it.¹¹ Aristotle says that the aim of education is to make the pupil like and dislike what he ought.¹² When the age for reflective thought comes, the pupil who has been thus trained in 'ordinate affections' or 'just sentiments' will easily find the first principles in Ethics; but to the corrupt man they will never be visible at all and he can make no progress in that science.¹³ Plato before him had said the same. The little human animal will not at first have the right responses. It must be trained to feel pleasure, liking, disgust, and hatred at those things which really are pleasant, likeable, disgusting and hateful.¹⁴ In the *Republic*, the well-nurtured youth is one 'who would see most clearly whatever was amiss in ill-made works of man or ill-grown works of nature, and with a just distaste would blame and hate the ugly even from his earliest years and would give delighted praise to beauty, receiving it into his soul and being nourished by it, so that he becomes a man of gentle heart. All this before he is of an age to reason; so that when Reason at length comes to him, then, bred as he has been, he will hold out his hands in welcome and recognize her because of the affinity he bears to her.'¹⁵ In early Hinduism that conduct in men which can be called good consists in conformity to, or almost participation in, the *Rta*—that great ritual or pattern of nature and supernature which is revealed alike in the cosmic order, the moral virtues, and the ceremonial of the temple. Righteousness, correctness, order, the *Rta*, is constantly identified with *satya* or truth, correspondence to reality. As Plato said that the Good was 'beyond existence' and Wordsworth that through virtue the stars were strong, so the Indian masters say that the gods themselves are born of the *Rta* and obey it.¹⁶ The Chinese also speak of a great thing (the greatest thing) called the *Tao*. It is the reality beyond all predicates, the abyss that was before the Creator Himself. It is Nature, it is the Way, the Road. It is the Way in which the universe goes on, the Way in which things everlastingly emerge, stilly and tranquilly, into space and time. It is also the Way which every man should tread in imitation of that cosmic and supercosmic progression, conforming all activities to that great exemplar.¹⁷ 'In ritual', say the *Analects*, 'it is harmony with Nature that is prized.'¹⁸ The ancient Jews likewise praise the Law as being 'true'.¹⁹

This conception in all its forms, Platonic, Aristotelian, Stoic, Christian, and Oriental alike, I shall henceforth refer to for brevity simply as 'the *Tao*'. Some of the accounts of it which I have quoted will seem, perhaps, to many of you merely quaint or even magical. But what is common to them all is something we cannot neglect. It is the doctrine of objective value, the belief that certain attitudes are really true, and others really false, to the kind of thing the universe is and the kind of things we are. Those who know the *Tao* can hold that to call children delightful or old men venerable is not simply to record a

¹⁰ *Centuries of Meditations*, i, 12.

¹¹ *De Civ. Dei*, xv, 22, Cf. *ibid.* ix. 5, xi. 28.

¹² *Eth. Nic.* 1104 B.

¹³ *Ibid.* 1095 B.

¹⁴ *Laws*, 653.

¹⁵ *Republic*, 402 A.

¹⁶ A. B. Keith, s.v. 'Righteousness (Hindu)' *Enc. Religion and Ethics*, vol. x.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, vol. ii, p. 454 B; iv. 12 B; ix. 87 A.

¹⁸ *The Analects of Confucius*, trans. Arthur Waley, London, 1938, i. 12

¹⁹ Psalm 119:151. The word is *emeth*, 'truth'. Where the *Satya* of the Indian sources emphasizes truth as 'correspondence', *emeth* (connected with a verb that means 'to be firm') emphasizes rather the reliability or trustworthiness of truth. *Faithfulness* and *permanence* are suggested by Hebraists as alternative renderings. *Emeth* is that which does not deceive, does not 'give', does not change, that which holds water. (See T. K. Cheyne in *Encyclopedia Biblica*, 1914, s.v. 'Truth'.)

psychological fact about our own parental or filial emotions at the moment, but to recognize a quality which *demand*s a certain response from us whether we make it or not. I myself do not enjoy the society of small children: because I speak from within the *Tao* I recognize this as a defect in myself—just as a man may have to recognize that he is tone deaf or colour blind. And because our approvals and disapprovals are thus recognitions of objective value or responses to an objective order, therefore emotional states can be in harmony with reason (when we feel liking for what ought to be approved) or out of harmony with reason (when we perceive that liking is due but cannot feel it). No emotion is, in itself, a judgement; in that sense all emotions and sentiments are alogical. But they can be reasonable or unreasonable as they conform to Reason or fail to conform. The heart never takes the place of the head: but it can, and should, obey it.

Over against this stands the world of *The Green Book*. In it the very possibility of a sentiment being reasonable—or even unreasonable—has been excluded from the outset. It can be reasonable or unreasonable only if it conforms or fails to conform to something else. To say that the cataract is sublime means saying that our emotion of humility is appropriate or ordinate to the reality, and thus to speak of something else besides the emotion; just as to say that a shoe fits is to speak not only of shoes but of feet. But this reference to something beyond the emotion is what Gaius and Titius exclude from every sentence containing a predicate of value. Such statements, for them, refer solely to the emotion. Now the emotion, thus considered by itself, cannot be either in agreement or disagreement with Reason. It is irrational not as a paralogism is irrational, but as a physical event is irrational: it does not rise even to the dignity of error. On this view, the world of facts, without one trace of value, and the world of feelings, without one trace of truth or falsehood, justice or injustice, confront one another, and no *rapprochement* is possible.

Hence the educational problem is wholly different according as you stand within or without the *Tao*. For those within, the task is to train in the pupil those responses which are in themselves appropriate, whether anyone is making them or not, and in making which the very nature of man consists. Those without, if they are logical, must regard all sentiments as equally non-rational, as mere mists between us and the real objects. As a result, they must either decide to remove all sentiments, as far as possible, from the pupil's mind; or else to encourage some sentiments for reasons that have nothing to do with their intrinsic 'justness' or 'ordinacy'. The latter course involves them in the questionable process of creating in others by 'suggestion' or incantation a mirage which their own reason has successfully dissipated.

Perhaps this will become clearer if we take a concrete instance. When a Roman father told his son that it was a sweet and seemly thing to die for his country, he believed what he said. He was communicating to the son an emotion which he himself shared and which he believed to be in accord with the value which his judgement discerned in noble death. He was giving the boy the best he had, giving of his spirit to humanize him as he had given of his body to beget him. But Gaius and Titius cannot believe that in calling such a death sweet and seemly they would be saying 'something important about something'. Their own method of debunking would cry out against them if they attempted to do so. For death is not something to eat and therefore cannot be *dulce* in the literal sense, and it is unlikely that the real sensations preceding it will be *dulce* even by analogy. And as for *decorum*—that is only a word describing how some other people will feel about your death when they happen to think of it, which won't be often, and will certainly do you no good. There are only two courses open to Gaius and Titius. Either they must go the whole way and debunk this sentiment like any other, or must set themselves to work to produce, from outside, a sentiment which they believe to be of no value to the pupil and which may cost him his life, because it is useful to us (the survivors) that our young men should feel it. If they embark on this course the difference between the old and the new education will be an important one. Where the old initiated, the new merely 'conditions'. The old dealt with its pupils as grown birds deal with young birds

when they teach them to fly; the new deals with them more as the poultry-keeper deals with young birds—making them thus or thus for purposes of which the birds know nothing. In a word, the old was a kind of propagation—men transmitting manhood to men; the new is merely propaganda.

It is to their credit that Gaius and Titius embrace the first alternative. Propaganda is their abomination: not because their own philosophy gives a ground for condemning it (or anything else) but because they are better than their principles. They probably have some vague notion (I will examine it in my next lecture) that valour and good faith and justice could be sufficiently commended to the pupil on what they would call 'rational' or 'biological' or 'modern' grounds, if it should ever become necessary. In the meantime, they leave the matter alone and get on with the business of debunking. But this course, though less inhuman, is not less disastrous than the opposite alternative of cynical propaganda. Let us suppose for a moment that the harder virtues could really be theoretically justified with no appeal to objective value. It still remains true that no justification of virtue will enable a man to be virtuous. Without the aid of trained emotions the intellect is powerless against the animal organism. I had sooner play cards against a man who was quite sceptical about ethics, but bred to believe that 'a gentleman does not cheat', than against an irreproachable moral philosopher who had been brought up among sharpers. In battle it is not syllogisms that will keep the reluctant nerves and muscles to their post in the third hour of the bombardment. The crudest sentimentalism (such as Gaius and Titius would wince at) about a flag or a country or a regiment will be of more use. We were told it all long ago by Plato. As the king governs by his executive, so Reason in man must rule the mere appetites by means of the 'spirited element'.²⁰ The head rules the belly through the chest—the seat, as Alanus tells us, of Magnanimity,²¹ of emotions organized by trained habit into stable sentiments. The Chest-Magnanimity-Sentiment—these are the indispensable liaison officers between cerebral man and visceral man. It may even be said that it is by this middle element that man is man: for by his intellect he is mere spirit and by his appetite mere animal.

The operation of *The Green Book* and its kind is to produce what may be called Men without Chests. It is an outrage that they should be commonly spoken of as Intellectuals. This gives them the chance to say that he who attacks them attacks Intelligence. It is not so. They are not distinguished from other men by any unusual skill in finding truth nor any virginal ardour to pursue her. Indeed it would be strange if they were: a persevering devotion to truth, a nice sense of intellectual honour, cannot be long maintained without the aid of a sentiment which Gaius and Titius could debunk as easily as any other. It is not excess of thought but defect of fertile and generous emotion that marks them out. Their heads are no bigger than the ordinary: it is the atrophy of the chest beneath that makes them seem so.

And all the time—such is the tragi-comedy of our situation—we continue to clamour for those very qualities we are rendering impossible. You can hardly open a periodical without coming across the statement that what our civilization needs is more 'drive', or dynamism, or self-sacrifice, or 'creativity'. In a sort of ghastly simplicity we remove the organ and demand the function. We make men without chests and expect of them virtue and enterprise. We laugh at honour and are shocked to find traitors in our midst. We castrate and bid the geldings be fruitful.

²⁰ *Republic*, 442 B, C.

²¹ Alanus ab Insulis. *De Planctu Naturae Prosa*, iii.



WYA Declaration on the Human Person

Toronto, Canada 2002

The WYA Declaration on the Human Person explores the question "Who am I?" or "Who is the human person?" The Declaration was drafted in 2002 for World Youth Day Toronto, Canada, and presented to Pope John Paul II.

We, young people of all nations, in solidarity with one another, believe that every human being has intrinsic and inalienable dignity that begins at conception and extends to natural death. This dignity, the most precious endowment of the human person, is inviolable. The dignity of the human person must be cherished in custom and protected by law. We recognize, celebrate, and pledge ourselves to defend the intrinsic dignity of every human person.

At the same time, as young people seeking our vocations, we ask ourselves, "Who am I?"

We know that the human person is free. Yet freedom, exercised solely for selfish or self-assertive ends, is radically incomplete.

We believe that the freedom of the human person is most fully and rightly lived in the gift of ourselves to others.

In the act of self-gift, the human person answers the question "Who am I?" through the experience of love. Love is the experience of freedom lived for the good of the other, the goods that make for genuine human flourishing. Thus, true love, freely given and received, is the experience of the transcendent which fulfills and completes every human being within the human family.